SPORTS

Great Balls of Fire

The sport of **PICKLEBALL** is set to get a boost in India with the launch of the World Pickleball League here

Six years ago, Tejas Mahajan made the switch from badminton to pickleball. He made rapid progress and went on to win multiple medals at the national and international level. The 26-year-old's latest triumph came at the Asia Pickleball Open in Thailand in February, where he picked up two golds and a bronze. More importantly, pickleball gave him an identity and means to earn a livelihood through which he has been able to pay off his home loan in Jalgaon and buy a shiny new motorcycle.

For the likes of Mahajan, there's more in store now with the announcement of the World Pickleball League that will start in a few months. Former Davis Cupper Gaurav Natekar's firm, Natekar Sports and Gaming, will be launching the enterprise in the country backed by Sony Entertainment Talent Ventures India. The six-team league will feature a mix of international and Indian players and see an investment of $10 million over the next 3-5 years.

"About a year ago, I realised the potential of pickleball during a tournament in Goa. The participation was good, building the court didn't cost much and it required little space. Besides, it included people of all ages with almost 35-40 per cent women. That said, it's an easy game to learn, but a tough one to master," says Natekar.



"We'll have talent searches, grassroots programmes. The idea is to build our own heroes through this league"

GAURAV NATEKAR
Natekar Sports and Gaming

Pickleball's origins

THE POWER OF PATIENCE

A steady approach has helped badminton player **Lakshya Sen** secure a spot in the upcoming Paris Olympics



After the China Masters in November last year, Lakshya Sen felt the need to hit pause. Since August, he had won just two matches in eight tournaments on the BWF World Tour, making it past the opening round only once. His qualification hopes for the Paris Olympics were hanging by a thread.

That's when he had a detailed discussion with coach Prakash Padukone to understand his shortcomings. That conversation seems to have done wonders for Sen, who made the cut for the Olympics in April. "He asked me to change my mindset, to look at winning a few matches every week rather than qualification on the whole," says the 22-year-old Sen.

The relentless tournament schedule until then had given Sen little time to focus on training; his recovery wasn't complete either. "The aim was to make the World Tour Finals in December, but when that didn't happen, it gave us a lot of breathing space to train well," he says.

For the next six weeks, Sen got back to the grind to raise his fitness levels. Sports psychologist Gayatri Vartak Madkekar (a constant since his under-14 days) and South African performance coach Paddy Upton worked with him on the mental